

**County Administration Workshop: July 2, 2026**

**1:30 p.m. – Board of Commissioners Conference Room**

Attending: Commissioners Ron A. Smith; Colene M. Martin; Gary L. Richardson; and Nikole Guzman, Recorder

Chair Ron Smith called the meeting to order at 1:30 p.m.

**1. Declaration of Potential Conflicts of Interest**

The board declared there are no potential conflicts of interest.

**2. Department Business**

**a. Human Resources**

- 1. Present Human Resources Position Requisitions, Insurance Renewals, and signing authority requests.** This matter was no longer relevant as a previous Admin Workshop answered the topic.
- 2. Request signing authority for PA's and PR's** This matter was no longer relevant as a previous Admin Workshop answered the topic.
- 3. Position Requisitions**
  - a. Forestry – Forestry Technician I – Changing Current Position Description**
  - b. Forestry – Forestry Technician II – Changing Current Position Description**
  - c. Forestry – Forester II – Changing Current Position Description**
  - d. Forestry – Forestry Project Foreman – Changing Current Position Description**
  - e. Forestry – Admin Secretary – Changing Current Position Description**

Natalie Eckhardt-Doupe Interim Human Resources Director presented several personnel requisitions related to the Forestry Department and reviewed the results of a comprehensive compensation study completed for Forestry classifications. Ms. Eckhardt-Doupe explained that Forestry job descriptions had not undergone a formal compensation review since 2017 and that the department has experienced ongoing recruitment and retention challenges. She reported that Forestry positions have remained vacant for extended periods despite repeated recruitment efforts, with applicant pools consisting of relatively few qualified candidates. The compensation study compared Josephine County positions to similar forestry classifications in comparable Oregon jurisdictions and identified compensation disparities, particularly at the entry-level positions.

Dave Streeter Forestry Director discussed the unique challenges associated with recruiting and retaining qualified forestry professionals. He explained that Josephine County competes directly with the Bureau of Land Management, the United States Forest Service, and private timber companies that often offer substantially higher wages. Mr. Streeter stated that because experienced forestry professionals are difficult to recruit, the department frequently hires employees with strong work ethics and trains them internally, only to lose those employees once they become qualified for higher-paying positions elsewhere. He further emphasized that Forestry operations generate sufficient revenue through the County's timber sale program to fully fund departmental personnel costs without relying upon General Fund resources and expressed his desire to retain the experienced employees currently serving the department.

Commissioner Richardson reviewed the compensation analysis and discussed the overall structure of the County's salary schedules. He observed that the County's entry-level wages appeared less competitive than comparable employers while upper-end wages remained relatively consistent with surrounding jurisdictions. Commissioner Richardson questioned whether future collective bargaining discussions should include evaluation of the progression between salary steps to improve recruitment and retention while maintaining long-term fiscal responsibility. Discussion followed regarding hiring employees above Step 1, possible future bargaining implications, and the differences between public and private sector compensation practices.

Matt Eide, Finance Director, discussed employee retention trends and explained that turnover commonly occurs during the first several years of employment before employees become invested in long-term retirement benefits

and public employment. Discussion also addressed the value of performance evaluations, employee development, and maintaining competitive compensation to improve retention. Commissioners emphasized the importance of regularly reviewing classifications and compensation studies rather than allowing positions to remain unchanged for extended periods. Ms. Eckhardt-Doupe advised that Human Resources is implementing a schedule for compensation reviews and supervisory training to ensure compliance with County personnel policies and improve consistency throughout County departments.

Commissioners expressed support for addressing the Forestry Department's recruitment and retention challenges and reached consensus supporting the proposed position reclassifications and personnel requisitions as presented.

**f. Legal – Law Library Assistant – Add Position and Job Description**

Ms. Eckhardt-Doupe presented a personnel requisition authorizing recruitment for the part-time Law Library Assistant position previously approved during the Fiscal Year 2026-2027 budget process. Commissioners acknowledged that the position had already been approved through the adopted budget and concurred with proceeding with recruitment

**g. Sheriff – Dispatcher – Re-fill vacant position, vacated June 2026**

**h. Sheriff – Deputy Corrections – Re-fill vacant position, vacated March 2026**

**i. Sheriff – Deputy Patrol – Re-fill vacant position, vacated April 2026**

Ms. Eckhardt-Doupe requested authorization to refill three Sheriff's Office positions that became vacant prior to adoption of the Fiscal Year 2026-2027 budget, including a recently vacated dispatcher position. She explained that the Sheriff's Office continues filling vacant positions in chronological order based upon previously authorized staffing levels and that the requested personnel requisitions represent replacement positions rather than newly created positions. Commissioners discussed the hiring process and requested that Human Resources provide a complete listing of remaining budgeted vacancies to assist the Board in tracking recruitment activities.

**4. Insurance Renewals**

**a. CIS – Property and Liability Insurance**

**b. Saif – Worker's Compensation Insurance**

Ms. Eckhardt-Doupe presented the annual renewal documents for the County's workers' compensation, liability, and property insurance coverage through SAIF and CIS. She explained that execution of the renewal documents was necessary to continue uninterrupted insurance coverage for the upcoming fiscal year. Commissioners concurred that continuation of the County's insurance coverage was necessary and authorized Ms. Eckhardt-Doupe to execute the required renewal documents on behalf of the County.

**3. BOARD BUSINESS**

- a. Appoint an Interim HR Director. This matter was no longer relevant as a previous Admin Workshop answered the topic.

**4. OTHER**

Commissioner Martin proposed implementing semiannual department presentations during County Administration Workshops to provide the Board with regular updates regarding departmental accomplishments, ongoing projects, staffing, operational challenges, strategic goals, and emerging issues. Commissioners discussed the value of maintaining regular communication with departments throughout the year rather than limiting discussions primarily to the annual budget process. It was suggested that each department receive two opportunities annually to present updates using a standardized reporting format that would allow the Board to better understand departmental priorities and long-term planning efforts. Commissioners expressed support for developing a reporting schedule and standardized outline for future presentations.

Commissioner Richardson discussed the importance of proactive strategic planning for County operations and infrastructure rather than reacting after significant problems arise. Discussion included long-term planning for technology, communications, facilities, equipment replacement, and other major capital investments. Commissioner Martin also discussed establishing an internal planning group to evaluate future facility improvements, maintenance priorities, and

capital projects in order to better coordinate long-term County investments. Commissioners agreed that additional strategic planning would improve budgeting decisions and organizational effectiveness.

Commissioners discussed the expiration of the Josephine County 4-H/Extension Service District reserve fund originally established for building maintenance. Discussion focused on the remaining balance within the reserve fund, possible future uses associated with the District's relocation, and whether the reserve fund should be continued or allowed to expire. Commissioners also discussed obtaining input from the District's citizen advisory committee before making long-term decisions regarding the reserve fund. Staff was directed to place the matter on a future Legal Counsel agenda to review applicable legal requirements and available options.

#### County Radio Communications System

Commissioners reviewed a recently completed Day Wireless assessment regarding the County's public safety radio communications system. The report identified numerous deficiencies throughout the communications network, including failed microwave paths, degraded signal strength, aging infrastructure, equipment failures, battery and repeater deficiencies, dispatch console issues, and multiple system components that have exceeded their expected service life. Commissioners expressed concern that the report concluded the existing communications system requires comprehensive modernization rather than incremental repairs.

Discussion focused on identifying potential funding opportunities for replacement of the radio system, including possible Full Faith and Credit financing, grant opportunities through FEMA and Oregon Emergency Management, and researching similar replacement projects completed by neighboring counties. Commissioners agreed that replacement of the communications system represents a significant public safety priority affecting the Sheriff's Office, Emergency Management, Public Works, and other County operations. Staff was directed to continue gathering cost estimates, funding information, and grant opportunities. Commissioners further agreed to include a standing agenda item during future County Administration Workshops to receive ongoing updates regarding the communications system until a long-term replacement strategy is established.

#### **5. ADDITIONAL SUBJECT MATTERS FROM COMMISSIONERS/ANNOUNCEMENTS:**

None heard.

The meeting adjourned at 2:36 p.m.